KENTUCKY COMMUNITY & TECHNICAL COLLEGE SYSTEM

ESSENTIAL SKILL 8 · FROM YOUR COLLEAGUES

Persuasive Speech Planning Team Challenge

Communication · Persuasive Speaking

Four short group activities that take students from persuasion basics to a speech plan: a review discussion, a fact/value/policy classification challenge, an organizational-pattern match-up, and an audience analysis discussion. Use them in sequence or one at a time.

Contributed by **Sherri Basil** and adapted with permission for *Designing Collaboration That Works*, the KCTCS faculty guide to Essential Skill 8. Student-facing sections are written to copy into Blackboard. Draft for review, in-house resource.

COURSE
Communication, persuasive speech unit

LENGTH
Four parts, about 20–30 minutes each

GROUP SIZE
3–4 students

FORMAT
Blackboard group discussion and group assignment

FINAL PRODUCT
Group summary, two charts, and an audience analysis summary

Closest level in the guide: **Level 2 · Structured**

1 · Quick | **2 · Structured** | 3 · Coordinated | 4 · Sustained

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Overview and Setup

FOR FACULTY

Learning Objectives

By completing this activity, students will be able to:

1. Summarize the purpose and function of persuasive speaking.
2. Compare and contrast questions of fact, value, and policy.
3. Distinguish among persuasive speech organizational patterns.
4. Determine an effective organizational pattern for a persuasive speech topic.
5. Participate in audience analysis discussions and provide meaningful feedback to peers.
6. Collaborate effectively with a small group to develop shared recommendations.

Group Size

3–4 students

Blackboard Setup

- Create a Blackboard Group Set
- Enable a Group Discussion Board
- Create a Group Assignment Submission
- Provide access to a shared collaboration space. (Teams or OneDrive Document)

Part 1: Persuasive Speaking Review

FOR FACULTY

Group Discussion Prompt

As a group, discuss the following questions:

- What is the primary purpose of persuasive speaking?
- How does persuasive speaking differ from informative speaking?
- Why is audience analysis important when persuading others?

Deliverable

Create a group response (150–250 words) that summarizes:

- The purpose of persuasive speaking
- The role of audience analysis
- Why persuasion is a valuable communication skill

Part 1: Persuasive Speaking Review

FOR STUDENTS

Instructions

Step 1: Meet with Your Group

Work collaboratively with your assigned group members to discuss the following questions:

1. What is the primary purpose of persuasive speaking?
2. How does persuasive speaking differ from informative speaking?
3. Why is audience analysis important when persuading others?

Step 2: Share Ideas

As a group, discuss each question and identify the most important concepts from the course materials. Be sure that all group members contribute to the discussion.

Step 3: Create a Group Summary

Develop a well-written group response that is **150-250 words** and includes:

- A summary of the purpose of persuasive speaking
- An explanation of the role of audience analysis
- A discussion of why persuasion is an important communication skill

Step 4: Submit Your Work

One group member should submit the final document to the Blackboard assignment area on behalf of the group.

Expectations for Collaboration

To successfully complete this activity:

- Participate actively in group discussions.
- Respect and consider the ideas of your teammates.
- Contribute meaningful content to the final summary.
- Work together to ensure the submission reflects the ideas of the entire group.

Part 2: Speech Topic Classification Challenge

FOR FACULTY

Faculty Overview

This collaborative activity helps students apply persuasive speaking concepts by identifying and classifying persuasive speech topics as questions of **fact**, **value**, or **policy**. Through discussion and analysis, students develop a deeper understanding of the different types of persuasive claims and learn how the type of claim influences speech development and organization.

Working in small groups encourages students to explain their reasoning, evaluate multiple perspectives, and build consensus, supporting both communication competency and collaboration skills. This activity serves as an excellent bridge between learning persuasive speech theory and selecting a topic for the persuasive speech assignment.

Essential Skill 8 Connection

This activity supports **Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams** by requiring students to:

- Exchange ideas and perspectives
- Explain and defend their reasoning
- Work together to classify topics
- Reach consensus on group responses
- Share responsibility for a common deliverable

Learning Objective

Upon completion of this activity, students will be able to:

- **Compare and contrast questions of fact, value, and policy by analyzing persuasive speech topics and providing evidence-based justification for their classifications.**

Activity Purpose

The purpose of this activity is to help students:

- Differentiate among the three types of persuasive propositions.
- Recognize how the purpose of a speech influences topic selection.
- Develop critical thinking and decision-making skills.
- Practice collaborative discussion and problem-solving.
- Prepare for selecting and developing their own persuasive speech topics.

Student Deliverable

Groups will analyze a series of persuasive speech topics and determine whether each represents a question of:

- Fact
- Value
- Policy

For each topic, students must provide a brief explanation supporting their classification.

Example Deliverable

Topic	Type of Question	Justification
Social media causes more harm than good.	Fact	The speaker must prove whether the statement is true or false.
Community colleges should offer free textbooks.	Policy	The topic proposes a specific course of action.
Capital punishment is unethical.	Value	The topic asks the audience to make a judgment regarding worth or morality.

Faculty Notes

Recommended Group Size

- 3-4 students

Estimated Time

- 20-30 minutes

Blackboard Tools

- Group Discussion Board
- Group Assignment or PowerPoint
- Shared Microsoft Word Document

Preparation for Future Assignments

This activity prepares students for:

- Topic selection
- Audience analysis
- Choosing an organizational pattern
- Developing persuasive speech outlines

By the end of the activity, students should be better equipped to identify the type of persuasive claim they plan to make in their own persuasive speeches and begin considering how that claim will shape their speech structure and supporting evidence.

Part 2: Speech Topic Classification Challenge

FOR STUDENTS

Student Instructions

Purpose

In this activity, you will work with your group to identify and classify persuasive speech topics as questions of **fact**, **value**, or **policy**. Understanding these types of persuasive claims will help you select and develop your own persuasive speech topic later in the course.

Learning Objective

By completing this activity, you will be able to:

- Compare and contrast questions of fact, value, and policy by analyzing persuasive speech topics and providing evidence-based justification for your classifications.

Directions

Step 1: Review the Types of Persuasive Claims

Before beginning, review the definitions of the three persuasive speech propositions discussed in class:

- **Question of Fact**: Seeks to determine whether something is true or false.
- **Question of Value**: Asks the audience to make a judgment about worth, importance, morality, or desirability.
- **Question of Policy**: Proposes a specific action, change, or solution.

Step 2: Discuss Sample Topics with Your Group

Working with your assigned group, review each persuasive speech topic provided by your instructor.

For each topic:

1. Determine whether it represents a question of **fact**, **value**, or **policy**.
2. Discuss your reasoning with your group members.
3. Reach a consensus on the best classification.
4. Record a brief explanation supporting your decision.

Step 3: Complete the Classification Chart

As a group, complete a chart similar to the example below:

Topic	Fact	Value	Policy	Why?
Social media causes more harm than good.	✓			The claim requires evidence to determine whether it is true or false.
Community colleges should offer free textbooks.			✓	The topic proposes a specific action or change.

Be sure to provide a clear explanation for each classification.

Step 4: Collaborate Effectively

To receive full credit:

- Participate in group discussions.
- Listen respectfully to differing viewpoints.
- Support your ideas with course concepts and examples.
- Help your group reach agreement on each classification.
- Contribute to the final submission.

Step 5: Submit Your Work

One group member should submit the completed classification chart to the Blackboard assignment area on behalf of the group.

Part 3: Organizational Pattern Match-Up

FOR FACULTY

Faculty Overview

In this part of the group activity, students work together to examine common persuasive speech organizational patterns and determine when each pattern is most effective. Students will review patterns such as **Problem-Solution**, **Problem-Cause-Solution**, **Monroe's Motivated Sequence**, **Comparative Advantages**, and **Topical Organization**.

The purpose of this activity is to help students understand that persuasive speeches are not organized randomly. The structure should match the speaker's purpose, topic, audience, and type of persuasive claim. By comparing organizational patterns and applying them to sample topics, students begin making more intentional choices about how to arrange their persuasive speeches.

This activity also supports collaboration because students must discuss options, explain their reasoning, compare different viewpoints, and reach agreement on the most appropriate organizational pattern for each topic. It gives students practice making communication decisions as a group before they apply those decisions individually to their own persuasive speech outlines.

Learning Objective

Upon completion of this activity, students will be able to:

Distinguish between persuasive speech organizational patterns and determine which pattern is most appropriate for a persuasive speech topic based on the purpose, audience, and type of claim.

Activity Purpose

This part of the assignment helps students:

- Identify common persuasive speech organizational patterns.
- Explain the purpose and function of each pattern.
- Connect speech topics to appropriate organizational structures.
- Determine how organization affects audience understanding and persuasion.
- Practice collaborative decision-making by discussing and justifying pattern choices.
- Prepare to select an organizational pattern for their own persuasive speech.

Suggested Organizational Patterns to Include

Faculty may choose to include the following patterns:

Problem-Solution

Students identify a problem and then present a solution.

Best for: Topics where the speaker wants the audience to understand an issue and support a specific solution.

Problem-Cause-Solution

Students explain a problem, identify what causes it, and then recommend a solution.

Best for: Topics where the audience needs to understand why the problem exists before considering a solution.

Monroe's Motivated Sequence

Students use a five-step persuasive structure: attention, need, satisfaction, visualization, and action.

Best for: Speeches that ask the audience to take action.

Comparative Advantages

Students compare multiple options and argue that one option is better than the others.

Best for: Topics where the speaker wants the audience to choose between alternatives.

Topical Organization

Students divide the topic into main points or categories.

Best for: Topics that can be organized by themes, reasons, or key ideas.

Student Deliverable

Groups should complete a recommendation chart that includes:

Speech Topic	Recommended Organizational Pattern	Reasoning
Example: Community colleges should offer free textbooks.	Problem-Solution	The topic identifies a problem related to textbook costs and proposes a specific solution.
Example: Students should use public speaking skills in the workplace.	Topical	The topic can be organized around several benefits or uses of public speaking skills.

Students should explain why the selected pattern is the best fit for each topic. The explanation should show that they understand both the topic and the organizational pattern.

Essential Skill 8 Connection

This activity supports **Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams** by asking students to:

- Work together to analyze communication choices.
- Compare multiple possible solutions.
- Explain and defend their reasoning.
- Listen to alternative viewpoints.
- Reach consensus on the best organizational pattern.
- Produce a shared group response.

Faculty Notes

This activity works well after students have learned the difference between questions of **fact**, **value**, and **policy**. Once students understand the type of persuasive claim being made, they are better prepared to select an organizational pattern that fits the topic.

Faculty may also use this part as a transition into the persuasive speech outline assignment. After groups practice with sample topics, students can apply the same process to their own speech topic and explain why they selected a specific organizational pattern.

Possible grading rubric

Total: 10 Points

Performance Expectations

Excellent (9-10 Points)

- Demonstrates a thorough understanding of persuasive speech organizational patterns.
- Provides strong justifications for pattern selections.
- Shows effective collaboration and teamwork.

Proficient (7-8 Points)

- Demonstrates an adequate understanding of organizational patterns.
- Provides reasonable explanations and participates in group discussions.

Developing (0-6 Points)

- Demonstrates limited understanding of organizational patterns.
- Provides incomplete or weak justifications.
- Shows minimal participation in the collaborative process.

Part 3: Organizational Pattern Match-Up

FOR STUDENTS

Student Instructions

Purpose

In this activity, you will work with your group to explore common persuasive speech organizational patterns and determine which pattern is most effective for various persuasive speech topics. Understanding how to organize a persuasive speech will help you select the best structure for your own speech later in the course.

Learning Objective

By completing this activity, you will be able to:

Distinguish between persuasive speech organizational patterns and determine which pattern is most appropriate for a persuasive speech topic based on the purpose, audience, and type of claim.

Directions

Step 1: Review Persuasive Speech Organizational Patterns

As a group, review the persuasive speech organizational patterns discussed in class:

- **Problem-Solution**
- **Problem-Cause-Solution**
- **Monroe's Motivated Sequence**
- **Comparative Advantages**
- **Topical Organization**

For each pattern, discuss:

- What is the purpose of the pattern?
- How is the speech organized?
- When is the pattern most effective?

Step 2: Define Each Organizational Pattern

Working together, create a brief definition for each pattern in your own words.

Your definitions should explain:

- How the pattern is structured
- What type of persuasive topic it supports
- Why a speaker might choose to use it

Step 3: Match Topics to Organizational Patterns

Review the persuasive speech topics provided by your instructor.

As a group:

1. Discuss each topic.
2. Determine which organizational pattern would be most effective.
3. Explain why that pattern is the best choice.
4. Reach a consensus before recording your answer.

Consider the following questions:

- Is the speaker proposing a solution?
- Does the audience need to understand the cause of a problem?
- Is the speaker asking the audience to take action?
- Is the speaker comparing multiple options?
- Would the topic be best organized around several key points?

Step 4: Complete the Recommendation Chart

Complete the chart below as a group.

Speech Topic	Recommended Organizational Pattern	Justification
Example: Community colleges should offer free textbooks.	Problem-Solution	The topic identifies a problem and proposes a solution.
Example: Students should develop stronger public speaking skills.	Topical	The topic can be organized around several benefits of public speaking.

Your justifications should clearly explain why the selected pattern is the best fit for the topic.

Step 5: Collaborate and Reach Consensus

Before submitting your work:

- Ensure all group members contribute to the discussion.
- Listen respectfully to different viewpoints.
- Support your recommendations using concepts from the course.
- Reach agreement on each organizational pattern selected.

Step 6: Submit Your Work

One member of the group should submit the completed recommendation chart through the Blackboard assignment link.

Part 4: Audience Analysis Collaboration

FOR FACULTY

This activity helps students understand that persuasive speaking is not only about choosing a topic or building an argument. It also requires speakers to consider the needs, values, beliefs, experiences, and possible resistance of the audience. By receiving feedback from peers, students begin to see their topic from multiple perspectives before they begin developing the speech.

Part 4 also strengthens collaboration because students must listen carefully, ask thoughtful questions, provide constructive feedback, and use group discussion to improve each speaker's topic direction. This part works especially well in Blackboard as a **Group Discussion Board** because students can post their topics, respond to peers, and return to the feedback later as they develop their outlines.

Learning Objective

Upon completion of this activity, students will be able to:

Participate in an audience analysis discussion board to gather and share feedback regarding various persuasive speech topics.

Activity Purpose

This part of the assignment helps students:

- Recognize the importance of audience analysis in persuasive speaking.
- Identify possible audience attitudes, beliefs, and concerns.
- Consider potential resistance to a persuasive topic.
- Give and receive constructive feedback.
- Use peer feedback to strengthen topic selection and speech planning.
- Practice respectful and purposeful collaboration.

Suggested Blackboard Setup

Faculty may set this section up as a **Group Discussion Board** in Blackboard Ultra.

Recommended setup:

- Create groups of **3 to 4 students**.
- Create one discussion board for each group or enable group discussions.
- Ask each student to post one possible persuasive speech topic.
- Require each student to respond to every group member.
- Have the group submit a brief audience analysis summary after the discussion.

Student Deliverable

Each student posts one potential persuasive speech topic and responds to all group members. After the discussion, the group submits a short summary identifying:

- Common audience characteristics.
- Possible audience concerns or objections.
- Suggested persuasion strategies.
- Topic adjustments based on peer feedback.

Suggested Discussion Questions for Students

Faculty may ask students to respond to peers using these questions:

- Who is the likely target audience for this topic?
- What might this audience already know or believe about the topic?
- What concerns or objections might the audience have?
- What evidence or examples might persuade this audience?
- How could the speaker adjust the topic to better connect with the audience?

Essential Skill 8 Connection

Part 4 supports **Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams** by requiring students to:

- Share ideas with a small group.
- Listen to and evaluate peer perspectives.
- Provide helpful and respectful feedback.
- Use group discussion to improve individual speech planning.
- Contribute to a shared audience analysis summary.